Jewish scholars have spent thousands of years inventing ways to dodge the strictures of the religion—to honor them in spirit, if not in practice. First-time visitors to Israel are occasionally confused by the “Shabbat elevators”, which run constantly throughout the day. The Torah forbids “building” on the Sabbath, a prohibition extended in modern times to closing an electrical circuit. Pressing the button for your floor would be an act of desecration. So the elevators, a common sight in hotels and tall apartment complexes, stop automatically on each floor, allowing observant passengers to reach their destination (albeit quite slowly).

These compromises, between Jewish tradition and the hum of modern life, are essential to a diverse, industrialized country like Israel. Yet rabbis and politicians who once supported them are now more and more likely to object. Partly this is simple arithmetic: as the ultra-Orthodox population has grown, so has their political clout. And, as the train saga illustrated, journalists and activists have become adept at using modern technology to battle modern life.

Guardians of Shabbat

A Friday evening in August, the sort of languid Shabbat when much of Israel seems to grind to a halt. In Jerusalem, though, thousands of protesters were on the streets, throwing stones at police and shattering the windows of a government building. The reason? A cinema.

Yes Planet, a local chain, had just opened a new sixteen-screen theater in Abu Tor, a mixed Jewish and Palestinian neighborhood south of the Old City. Unusually for Jerusalem, it would stay open on Shabbat. A few months earlier, a second new cinema had tried to do business on the sabbath. The municipality refused because it was built on state-owned land; the case eventually found its way to the supreme court. But the Yes Planet theater was built on private land, and the city couldn’t block it. So the ultra-Orthodox community tried to. Flyers quickly went up in their neighborhoods, calling the cinema a “plague” on the city. “Shabbat in Jerusalem is in terrible danger,” they warned.

Jewish law forbids almost all forms of work on Shabbat, except activities defined as *pikuach nefesh*—preserving a life. Thus a doctor can perform emergency surgery, but not a cosmetic procedure, and an observant Jew can